The House That Kept the Night

A dark fantasy novella

1. The Customer after Dark

Autumn 250 IS

The man on the kitchen floor was still alive when Mara dropped the canvas.

She knew him. Bren made the little barrels in which her sister grew mint. He had once spent half a morning explaining to Tessa why a barrel could not be made wider after the hoops were fitted, and Tessa had spent the other half explaining why it ought to be possible. Now he sat with his back against an overturned chair, one sleeve rolled above the elbow. Blood shone between his fingers.

“Pick that up,” said Yseld.

Mara did not move.

The kitchen smelled of boiled linen and the apples Mara had brought with her delivery. Beyond its broken outer wall, the monastery garden lay dark beneath the first autumn stars. She could see the way she had come: the cracked step, the rosemary gone woody, the gate hanging from one hinge. Her satchel stood beside it. She had left the flap open because she expected to be paid.

“He fell,” Yseld said.

Bren looked at Mara, then at the gate.

It was the smallest movement. Afterwards she would remember it with a hatred that belonged nowhere useful. He had meant to warn her. His eyes had given her away.

She ran.

The hanging gate struck her shoulder. She shoved through it, caught her satchel by its strap and almost fell when it held her back. For an instant she believed someone had seized it. Then the strap tore and she was in the garden, boots slipping on fallen pears.

Behind her, a chair scraped.

The road to Rookharbour was sixteen kilometres long. She had walked it that afternoon under a sky full of returning rooks, thinking about the silver Yseld owed her and the lamp oil it would buy. Now the length of it opened in her mind like a sea.

She reached the narrow place beside the chapel.

Yseld caught her there.

One hand gripped the back of her coat. Mara twisted, heard a seam break and drove her elbow backwards. It struck something hard. Yseld gasped. That ordinary sound gave Mara a wild moment of hope. She dragged her knife from its little sheath at her waist.

It was a sail-mender's knife, blunt at the point and sharp along the inside curve. She had used it that morning to trim a fraying bolt rope.

“Don't,” Yseld said.

Mara drew the knife across Yseld's gripping hand.

Yseld struck her against the chapel wall.

The impact drove the breath from her. Before she could draw another, a mouth closed against the side of her neck.

Pain flashed through her shoulder and down her arm. She felt teeth, then a terrible sustained pulling. Her knife struck the stones. She tried to shout Bren's name, but her jaw would not make the shape.

Across the courtyard, the kitchen door remained open.

Someone stood in it.

Then even that rectangle of yellow light became difficult to see.

Yseld lowered her carefully. Mara hated the care. It meant there was time for care, time in which somebody could still do something else.

“Listen to me.”

She could hear water.

“Mara.”

Yseld had asked her name on the first visit. She had asked where Mara lived, whether the girl at the ropewalk was her sister, how long the sisters had been alone. Mara had mistaken the questions for kindness.

Something warm touched her lips.

She turned her face away.

Yseld held her jaw.

“Swallow.”

Mara tried to say no. Blood entered her mouth. Some of it went down when she coughed. Yseld pressed her own bleeding wrist harder against her lips and waited.

The stars beyond the chapel roof had begun to move. Mara thought of Tessa standing on a chair to reach their highest shelf. She had promised to repair the chair's loose rung. If she could remember that clearly enough, perhaps she could also remember how to get up.

“Good,” Yseld whispered.

The word followed her down.

There was a bell in the darkness.

It rang once, then stopped halfway through a second stroke. Footsteps hurried past. Someone was crying, though every time Mara turned her head the crying came from the same place again.

She lay on something that scratched her cheek. Her neck hurt. Her chest hurt. The rest of her body seemed to have been taken apart and put back with hot wire.

She called for her mother.

An answer came in an unfamiliar woman's voice.

“She's dead, love.”

Mara knew that. The knowledge had lived with her for five years. She could not understand why somebody had brought it into this place to hurt her.

A hand steadied her head. She vomited. The hand held her while another cleaned her mouth.

Sometimes she opened her eyes and saw a low stone ceiling. Once she saw Bren kneeling beside a basin, his face grey. She asked him to fetch Tessa. He made a sound and looked away.

Later, Yseld sat beside her with a needle.

Mara watched the thread passing through the woman's cut hand.

“You have made a nuisance of this,” Yseld said.

The absurdity nearly made her laugh. What came out was a thin whimper.

The bell rang again.

“They can't come in,” Yseld told her.

Mara had not asked who.

“It's only the room remembering. Keep your eyes on me.”

She did, because everything else moved.

Near dawn, the fever changed.

The heat went out of her limbs so quickly that she thought someone had opened the roof to snow. She drew a breath. Another followed. Beneath the bandages, her pulse went on with an unfamiliar hesitation.

There was a smell in the room.

It made the back of her tongue ache.

Bren had returned. A small pottery cup shook in his good hand. The other arm was freshly wrapped.

Mara tried to sit up. Pain caught her by the throat and dropped her flat.

“Slowly,” Yseld said.

She slid an arm behind Mara's shoulders and brought the cup close.

Mara knew what was in it.

She had known from the moment Bren entered. Her body knew it with a certainty deeper than the names she gave things. She could smell his sleeve, the damp cloth beneath it, a bright trace where he had missed a spot on his thumb.

“No,” she said.

The word was little more than breath.

“Then you will keep hurting.”

Mara looked at Bren.

He was watching the cup.

“Tell her,” Yseld said.

He swallowed. “You should drink.”

Mara understood that he was afraid of being made to say more.

She pushed at the cup. Her fingers closed around Yseld's wrist instead, and suddenly she was trying to bring it nearer. She stopped herself with such force that pain burst white behind her eyes.

For a moment nobody moved.

“What have you done?” she asked.

Yseld looked tired. There were dried bloodstains on her collar and a little crookedness in the stitches Mara had made necessary.

“Kept you.”

Bren's eyes closed.

Mara drank.

It was warm. It tasted of iron and something she had no name for, something that made the room pull back into its proper shape. She hated how eagerly she swallowed. She hated the little sound she made when Yseld moved the cup away.

It did not stop her neck hurting. When she tried to breathe too deeply, the bandages pulled. Her hands still shook.

But she could think.

That was worse for a while.

Yseld laid her down again. Bren went out carrying the empty cup as if it were something breakable beyond repair.

High in the wall was a narrow ventilation slit. Pale morning gathered behind the rag stuffed into it. Mara remembered mornings in the sail loft, how the light entered slowly and found the needles before it found anything else.

She reached.

Yseld was at the door, speaking to Bren. Neither saw her fingers touch the edge of the rag.

A thread of light fell across two knuckles.

Mara screamed.

Yseld crossed the room and knocked her hand away. The movement tore at Mara's neck. She screamed again, and the room's old bell rang through the sound of it.

“Look at me.”

Her skin had reddened. A blister was rising beside the second knuckle.

“Look at me, Mara.”

Yseld caught her good hand and held it against her own chest. Under the palm was a slow, stubborn beat.

“You must learn what mornings are now.”

On the eighteenth day of autumn, while Rookharbour's bakers opened their shutters and Tessa put two bowls on the table before remembering that Mara had not come home, Mara lay beneath a ruined monastery and watched a woman repair the cloth over the light.

Every stitch was small and neat.

2. A Place at the Table

Winter 250 IS - two months later

Yseld owned five cups and only one chair that did not wobble.

Mara learned this while she was too weak to leave the kitchen. She learned which pan leaked, which stair had a rotten edge and which window needed two layers of cloth because the sun found it even through rain. She learned that Yseld liked to hear somebody working in the next room.

For the first three weeks, there had been no next room. There had been the bed, the basin and the effort of sitting up. The wound at her throat throbbed when she swallowed. Her burned fingers swelled, peeled and left a tender patch that caught against linen. Yseld changed the dressings without complaint.

Sometimes Mara found herself waiting for her.

That was the part she told nobody, later.

“Keep the needle lower,” Yseld said now.

Mara was repairing a curtain. “I know how to sew.”

“You knew how to sew when you could afford to prick yourself.”

The needle had already gone through her thumb twice. Hunger made her clumsy before she properly felt hungry. Yseld could identify the change from the sound of her working.

She set a cup beside Mara.

“Who?”

“Drink before it cools.”

“Who?”

Yseld pulled out the good chair and sat. Rain tapped into a bowl on the hearth.

“A fisherman. You don't know him.”

Mara put down the needle.

The woman sighed. “What would knowing help?”

Mara had tried not drinking. She had lasted until her legs shook too badly to carry her to the door. She had tried the blood of a rabbit Yseld brought back from the verge. For one night the terrible edge had softened. The following evening she had spent an hour staring at the thin blue veins in her own wrist before Yseld took her hands and told her, almost gently, that she would find nothing there.

Now the cup stood within reach.

She drank it while Yseld watched.

Afterwards, they sat with the rain between them.

“When I was an apprentice,” Yseld said, “we slept above the workshop, six of us in a room meant for flour. Every morning somebody trod on my hair.”

Mara kept her eyes on the curtain.

“I thought getting a bed to myself would be the greatest thing that ever happened to me.”

“Was it?”

Yseld smiled without showing her teeth. “For about a week.”

The kitchen held little scraps of her former life. A brass hairpin. A cracked blue tile wrapped in cloth. A charcoal drawing of a harbour, worn almost white where somebody had folded it. None explained her. Mara had searched them while Yseld slept and felt ashamed afterwards, then angry at the shame.

“You could let Bren go,” she said.

“Bren goes where he likes.”

“He doesn't look as if he does.”

Yseld's smile disappeared.

The change was small enough that Mara used to pretend she had imagined it.

“Finish the curtain.”

Mara bent her head.

Bren had gone to the rope shed the morning after the turning. Yseld told Mara he had described an unexpected coastal job, a boat leaving on the tide, excellent money. Mara imagined Tessa asking why she had not come home for her other coat. She imagined Bren answering.

She sent a letter after the second week. Yseld put paper, ink and a pen beside the bed and told her to describe a long sail-repair job farther down the coast. Good wages. Work through the winter. No need to worry.

Mara wrote that she would send money.

“Tell her you are well,” Yseld said.

Her bandages smelled sour. She wrote it anyway.

No answer had come.

By winter, the nights were long enough for the road.

Mara waited until Yseld left to meet someone beyond the headland. Then she put on her old coat, wound a scarf around her throat and went through the garden gate.

The latch had not been locked.

For the first kilometre she kept looking behind her.

The road shone with rain. Her boots found holes she had remembered as shallow. Twice she stopped to rest beneath a tree, furious with the weakness of a body that could wrench a stuck bolt out of wood and then tremble after walking uphill.

At the lime shed, she checked the shutter before going on. It still closed. If she could not get home before morning, the room behind it would be dark.

She reached Rookharbour more than five hours after leaving.

The town had changed its smells. No fresh fruit now; smoke, cabbage, wet wool, the sweetness of cider warming in kitchens. From a house near the brook came a Low Meridian song about a sailor whose wife made him sleep with his boots outside. A Serev woman's high, clear voice took the last line, and three lower voices ruined the harmony together.

Mara stopped in the street to listen.

Then she began to cry.

She had not cried properly since the garden. Pain had wrung water out of her eyes. Terror had done the same. This was different, and she had no strength ready for it.

When she reached the rope shed, Harl's lamp was still burning downstairs.

Mara went round the back.

The stair creaked in its old places. Someone had finally replaced the broken rung in the little chair outside their door.

She raised her hand.

The door opened before she knocked.

Tessa stood in a nightdress with a shawl dragged crookedly over it. She stared for a moment, then hit Mara in the chest.

Not hard. Hard enough.

“Where have you been?”

“I wrote.”

Tessa hit her again.

“I know you wrote.”

Mara caught her wrist. She meant only to stop the next blow. Tessa drew a sharp breath, and Mara let go at once.

Red marks stood where her fingers had been.

They both looked at them.

“Come in,” Tessa said.

The room was smaller than Mara remembered. Two bowls hung from the shelf. Their mother's blue scarf still covered the draught beneath the window. On the table was a pot of mint, doing badly.

Tessa shut the door.

“I went to the monastery,” Tessa said. “Bren was there. He showed me the canvas and told me you'd left on a boat. Harl asked every captain she knew. I went down to the quay every time a sail came in.”

Mara watched her fingers twist in the shawl.

“Then your letter came. It didn't sound like you.”

“I was tired.”

“You wrote that the weather was agreeable.”

Despite everything, Mara almost laughed.

Tessa's face crumpled. She turned away with an angry movement and wiped her eyes against the shawl.

“I thought you might have decided it was easier.”

“What?”

“Without me.”

Mara took a step towards her.

Tessa turned back. She was so close that Mara could smell the warm place beneath her jaw. The room held the little sounds of her: breath catching, cloth brushing skin, her pulse beating quickly from anger.

Mara stopped.

“Don't come nearer.”

Her sister went very still.

Mara had imagined telling her a hundred times on the road. In none of those imaginings had she been able to smell Tessa's blood.

She sat on the floor with her back against the bed.

“There is something wrong with me.”

It took a long time.

Tessa asked questions Mara could not answer. She asked them again in different words, as if the right arrangement might make the facts change. When Mara unwound the scarf, Tessa knelt beside her but did not touch the scar.

“That woman?”

Mara nodded.

“I'll fetch Cael.”

“No.”

“He knows about these things.”

“So does she.”

Tessa looked at her.

“That isn't the same.”

Downstairs, Harl coughed. A chair scraped across the kitchen flags.

Mara flinched.

“She's made soup,” Tessa said. “She makes too much when she's worried. There are jars of it everywhere.”

“I can't.”

“I didn't mean you had to eat it.”

They sat without speaking. Tessa pulled their mother's scarf from beneath the window and laid it across Mara's knees. Cold air crept into the room.

“You should put that back.”

“You should stop telling me what to do for one minute.”

Mara held the cloth.

They had scarcely begun talking again when a pebble struck the window.

Mara knew.

Below, in the alley beside the rope shed, Yseld stood with rain glittering on her hair.

She looked up and raised one hand, as though greeting a neighbour.

Mara had three hours left before dawn. She could not get back to the monastery in three hours.

Yseld knew that too.

At the bottom of the stairs she took Mara's arm.

“There's a covered fish cart waiting.”

She had lined its box with double canvas and fitted a solid lid. Mara would lie among empty baskets while the driver took her home through the morning.

Mara tried to pull away. Yseld's fingers tightened.

“Your sister has grown,” she said. “She looked younger when I last saw her.”

Above them, a floorboard creaked.

Mara went with her.

3. The Man with the Lamp

Spring 251 IS - six months after turning

Tessa chose the lime shed because it was the one place Mara had told her could keep out the morning.

They had been trying to meet since winter. Yseld began taking Mara with her whenever she left, or sent Bren to wait in the kitchen. Twice he passed on a scrap of Tessa's writing. The first proposed meeting never happened. At the second, Yseld arrived early, and Tessa watched from the trees while her sister walked past beside the woman who had hurt her.

Now a journey farther down the coast had kept Yseld away for two nights. Mara had leave to collect linen from the lime shed. Tessa had been waiting for an errand like that.

Mara found a sprig of mint pushed through the crack beside its door.

For a moment she stood staring at it. Then she looked back along the road, where the last of the evening lay grey between the trees.

Someone moved inside.

“It's only me,” Tessa said.

Mara opened the door.

It was not only Tessa.

Brother Cael stood beside the empty lime trough. He had a lamp in one hand and a short crossbow in the other.

Mara stepped backwards.

“Put it down,” Tessa said.

“Let me look at her.”

“You promised.”

The bolt was pointed at the floor. That did not make it harmless. Mara could see the nick in its iron head.

Cael had tended their mother through her last fever. Mara remembered his sleeves rolled to the elbow and the way he had washed his hands even when he was too tired to answer a question. She had never seen him hold a weapon.

Now she could not stop seeing it.

“I can leave,” she said.

Cael looked at her face. His gaze went to the scarf around her throat, then to her hands.

Very slowly, he set the crossbow behind the trough.

“You can.”

Tessa moved aside.

Mara came in.

The shed smelled of damp lime and old straw. Cael had covered the cracks in the shutter with a piece of dark cloth. Mara noticed that before she noticed anything else, and something inside her loosened.

He asked if he could examine her neck.

She took off the scarf herself.

His hands were warm. He touched lightly around the scar, asked where she still had pain and waited for her answer. When he looked at her burned fingers, his mouth tightened.

“How long?”

“The first morning.”

The skin had healed shiny and paler than the rest. On cold nights the knuckles ached.

“And the woman who did this?”

Mara looked at Tessa.

Her sister was studying a crack in the wall with an effort that made it obvious she already knew the name.

“Yseld.”

Cael sat on the edge of the trough.

“I've heard it.”

“She said you'd kill me.”

“I thought I might have to.”

Tessa turned. “Cael.”

“She deserves a true answer.”

Mara wanted to run again. It was the quiet way he spoke that made it worse. Yseld shouted when she wanted something. This man could have killed her carefully.

“And now?”

He rubbed a hand over his face.

“Now I am looking at you.”

Outside, rain began in the leaves.

Tessa had brought a bag. She took from it a folded blanket, a heel of bread, two apples grown soft in storage and a little jar of salve. She set them out one by one, then stared at the bread.

“I forgot.”

Mara picked it up and held it between her hands.

“It still smells good.”

“Harl put butter in it. She said you always ate better if she could make it difficult for you to call something charity.”

For the first time that evening Cael smiled.

The smile faded when he saw Mara watching the side of his neck.

She looked down quickly.

“When did you last eat?”

“Two nights ago.”

It had been more than that. Yseld had missed a meeting, come home furious, and told Mara to be patient. Then she had gone out again without saying where.

Cael waited.

“Four,” Mara said.

Tessa made a small movement towards her.

“No,” Cael said.

“I wasn't going to.”

“You're seventeen.”

“I know how old I am.”

He looked ashamed of his sharpness. Tessa folded the blanket again with unnecessary force.

Cael took a clean cup from his pack.

Mara watched him unwrap a small blade.

“You don't have to,” she said.

“I know.”

He asked Tessa to hold the lamp. There was no ceremony in it. He did what he had come prepared to do, awkwardly because it was his own arm, and swore once under his breath.

Tessa snorted.

“You tell the children not to say that.”

“The children rarely listen.”

Mara turned her face away until he had bound his arm.

Then the cup was in her hands.

He had not filled it to the brim. It held what she needed, enough that the smell made the cramped shed seem to have narrowed around it.

“Will it make you ill?” she asked.

“It may make me foolish if I stand too fast.”

“That's not an answer.”

“It's what you need to worry about tonight.”

She drank.

Tessa kept her eyes on Mara's face. Mara wished she would look away, then wished she never would.

The rain grew louder.

Afterwards Cael ate the bread with the determination of a man who did not want anybody watching him for weakness.

“I can't cure it,” he said.

Mara had not asked. She had been trying not to ask for months.

She set the cup down so carefully it barely made a sound.

“I know people who may help you live,” he continued. “That is a different thing.”

“She'll follow.”

“Then we will need somewhere she can't come and go unnoticed.”

“She can get into houses.”

“So can people with ladders. Tell me how she gets into yours.”

It was the first useful question anyone had asked.

Mara told him about the kitchen loft and the service crypt, about the garden gate, about the way Yseld always returned before dawn and checked every curtain with her fingers. She did not tell him everything. Some details still felt like family secrets.

Cael listened. When he suggested the infirmary's back room, Mara shook her head.

“She said you burned a woman alive.”

The shed became very quiet.

Tessa looked at him.

Cael put down the bread.

“I set fire to a room with a vampire in it,” he said.

“Was there anyone else?”

He closed his eyes.

“Her brother.”

Mara could hear the rain hitting the trough behind him.

“He lived. I carried him out. He lost the use of a hand.”

“Did you know he was there?”

“No.”

“Did you ask?”

Cael opened his eyes.

“No.”

Tessa sat beside Mara.

Neither of them said anything that made the answer easier.

At last Cael reached behind the trough, lifted the crossbow and pulled the bolt free. He laid the two pieces apart.

“I cannot make you trust me by regretting it,” he said.

Mara looked at his bandaged arm.

She wished good people had a shape she could recognise before she needed them.

They stayed until the rain thinned. Cael and Tessa would walk towards town and sleep at the charcoal burners' hut, whose owners expected them. Mara would go the remaining seven kilometres to the monastery. Her bed was still there, and the tools her mother had given her, and a woman who knew how little she yet understood.

At the door, Tessa embraced her.

Mara kept her face turned aside.

“You can come home,” Tessa whispered.

It was not a plan. It did not make the road shorter or the morning kinder.

Mara carried it back anyway.

Yseld was in the kitchen, sewing a button onto Mara's coat.

She glanced up.

“You look better.”

Mara took off her wet scarf.

“The walk helped.”

Yseld pulled the thread taut between her hands. The button turned once in the lamplight.

“Who fed you?”

Mara had thought of many lies on the road.

She discovered, standing there, that she was tired of all of them.

“Someone who wasn't afraid of me.”

For a long moment Yseld did not move.

Then she bit through the thread.

4. The Short Nights

Summer 251 IS - nine months after turning

By summer, Mara had begun to recognise the people who looked away when she passed.

The fisherman with the patched green sleeve. The woman who carried laundry between the headland houses. Bren, always Bren, though sometimes he tried to smile first.

Yseld sent her to meet them.

At the beginning she called it fetching supper. Later she stopped naming it at all. A place, a time, a clean bottle wrapped in cloth. Mara went because she was hungry and because the people she was meeting were more frightened of what might happen if she did not.

Cael had found a handful of adults prepared to help her. On those nights she walked to the lime shed or a shuttered room at the infirmary. A visit to town meant staying behind its opaque shutters through the following day, then returning the next night. She came back hating the monastery more sharply. There were not yet enough people. The gaps took her back to Yseld.

In midsummer Bren missed a meeting.

Yseld handed Mara a bottle.

“Go to his house.”

“I was there last month.”

“Then you know the way.”

“He looked ill.”

Yseld stood very still beside the table. Outside, swallows swept through the open chapel roof.

“Do you imagine I don't notice?”

Mara said nothing.

“Three have gone. One took his whole family inland without a word. Another has decided his priest can protect him. Perhaps you would like to ask your friends to make up the difference.”

There was genuine exhaustion in her voice. Mara had once found that persuasive.

She took the bottle.

Bren's cottage stood above the eastern gardens, six hours away by the road and lane. Mara reached it after midnight. His wife opened the door, saw what Mara carried and called into the darkness behind her.

Bren came with his shirt unfastened.

“Not tonight.”

He said it to the floor.

Mara could see a bruise beneath his collar and the little effort it cost him to stand upright. From the next room came a child's sleeping cough.

“She sent you?”

Mara nodded.

“Tell her I wasn't here.”

His wife laughed once, without humour.

Bren looked at her. “Please.”

Mara put the bottle on the doorstep.

“Go inside.”

Neither moved.

“Bren. Go inside.”

He shut the door slowly, waiting for her to change her mind.

Mara stood beneath the eaves until the light behind the curtain went out.

She could have waited out the day in Cael's shuttered room, then returned to the monastery the following night.

Instead she went to Harl's.

Harl opened the rope shed's back door in her nightcap.

“About time,” she said.

For six nights Mara slept in the little storeroom off the downstairs kitchen. Cael came and went. Tessa arrived from Briarbridge, where Nessa had begun teaching her to distinguish remedies that helped from remedies that merely made people feel attended to. Mara's tools went onto a shelf beside Harl's jars of soup.

They did not call it an escape.

The word seemed likely to draw attention.

Yseld came on the seventh night.

Mara was alone in the kitchen, repairing a fisherman's coat. Tessa had gone to the infirmary. Harl slept upstairs.

The back door opened.

Yseld looked around at the cups, the hanging herbs and the heap of boots beneath the bench.

“You didn't take your other scarf.”

She put it on the table.

Mara laid down her needle.

“I have it now.”

“Is that all?”

The town was quiet. Summer dawn would come soon.

“You should go.”

Yseld ran a finger along the back of a chair. Harl had tied a cushion to it because her hips ached.

“I looked after you.”

Mara remembered the basin, the clean cloth against her mouth, waking to find someone still sitting beside her.

“Yes.”

“You would have died.”

“You were the one killing me.”

Yseld's face changed as if Mara had slapped her.

For a moment Mara believed she might leave. Then she saw the little oil flask beside her hand.

“Why did you bring that?”

Yseld looked towards the narrow stair.

Mara stood.

The flask struck the floor between them. Oil splashed over the woven mat. Yseld took the lamp from the wall.

Mara caught her wrist before she could throw it.

They hit the table together. The lamp broke against its edge.

Fire leapt up the hanging cloth.

Yseld drove Mara backwards into the storeroom door. Pain burst through her shoulder. Mara struck at her face and felt skin tear under her nails. Yseld's teeth caught the side of her hand.

Above them, Harl shouted.

Mara tried to turn her head.

Yseld gripped her jaw.

“Look what happens when you leave a door open.”

Harl came down the stairs holding the heavy iron pan in which she baked winter pies.

She hit Yseld behind the ear.

The sound was appalling.

Yseld staggered. Harl struck again, missed and fell against the table. Mara pulled free as burning cloth dropped between them.

“Back door,” she gasped.

Harl was coughing. She had lost a slipper.

Mara got an arm beneath her shoulders and dragged her through the doorway. The yard beyond had begun to pale. She felt morning on the back of her neck, then on the shoulder where her coat had torn.

She pulled Harl beneath the lean-to.

Behind them Yseld stumbled out with a hand clamped to her head. Blood ran between her fingers. For an instant Mara saw an ordinary frightened woman looking for shade.

Then she was gone through the covered passage beside the sheds.

Harl tried to stand.

“My house.”

Mara held her.

“My house, you stupid girl.”

She did not say which girl she meant.

Neighbours came with buckets. Someone pulled a tarpaulin across the lean-to. Tessa arrived barefoot, white-faced, and knelt beside Mara without asking a question.

The pain in Mara's shoulder had become too large to belong to her. She smelled her own burned skin beneath the smoke.

Harl sat against the wall, weeping with rage.

“The good pan,” she said.

Tessa started laughing and could not stop. Then she was crying too.

The kitchen survived. The storeroom roof did not.

For days afterwards Mara woke convinced she could smell fire. Cael changed the dressings and told her when he needed to hurt her. He no longer promised that something would only sting.

The wall captain came to the infirmary. Harl met him outside the room.

“Ask her who did it,” he said.

“I know who did it.”

“Then let me hear it from her.”

“When she can sit up.”

He was a man accustomed to doors opening. Harl had owned hers longer than he had held his office. He went away angry.

Yseld did not come.

A fisherman saw her later that month at a shelter farther down the coast, with a cloth tied round her head. Others stopped admitting they had seen her at all.

Mara travelled to Briarbridge in the closed body of a produce cart. Tessa rode beside the driver, checking the canvas at every halt. They stopped overnight halfway up the wet road, and the following afternoon Nessa's hands opened the dark around Mara.

“This one's yours, then?” the midwife asked Tessa.

“She's her own.”

“Good. I haven't room for another baby.”

Mara tried to smile. The movement pulled at her neck and shoulder.

Nessa saw.

“Don't waste that on me. Save it for when you want something.”

She shut the shutters, and Tessa helped Mara into a clean bed.

For the first time since autumn, the person outside her door was somebody she had asked to stay.

5. The Pear Tree

Autumn 251 IS - one year after turning

Nessa kept a ladder beneath her oldest pear tree because she no longer trusted Tessa to ask for it before climbing.

“If I hear you fall,” she said, “I'll finish my tea before I come out.”

“You don't drink tea.”

“I'll start.”

Mara listened from the doorway as the two of them argued in the garden. Night had arrived with a clear chill. Pears lay on the grass in little bruised constellations, and somewhere beyond the brook a bell stag was ringing its antlers against a tree.

Her shoulder had taken most of the summer to close. The skin remained tight, and reaching above her head drew a line of pain down her arm. Nessa had given her a length of smooth wood and made her lift it a little each evening.

“Again,” she said now.

Mara lifted.

“You're watching the pears.”

“They seem happier.”

“They haven't met the wasps yet.”

Tessa dropped from the lowest branch carrying fruit in the front of her skirt.

Her hair had grown long enough to knot at the back of her head. There was dirt on one cheek and a small knife at her belt that Mara had never seen before.

“Where did you get that?”

“I work here.”

“I know. I only meant -- ”

Tessa raised an eyebrow.

Mara stopped.

That happened more often now.

The house held three beds and a room where Nessa treated people. Mara occupied a little former drying chamber beneath the stairs, its shutter thick enough to make noon complete darkness. At night she mended clothes, sharpened garden tools and learned the sounds of the village.

Aelri families across the brook sang while preserving nuts, their Bough words falling into patterns she almost understood. Downstream, the mill wheel knocked once in every turn. Ruun children had made a game of jumping the narrow drainage cuts after rain, to the fury of parents washing mud out of their clothes.

The forest beyond all of it spoke in calls Mara could not yet place.

One evening Nessa took her to see a grove of luminous fungus.

They walked slowly because of Mara's shoulder. Between the trees, pale light gathered along fallen branches. A moth as large as Mara's spread hand settled on Tessa's sleeve.

“Don't move,” Nessa said.

Tessa held her arm out, trying not to laugh.

The wings opened. Light showed through them like milk through thin cloth.

Mara had been so occupied with what darkness had taken that she had not expected it to contain anything she wanted.

The gathering came a week before the anniversary.

Long tables stood in the common beneath lanterns. Families brought bread, nuts, bowls of beans and whatever fruit they could spare. A Kharad potter played a little reed instrument with such solemnity that the children copied his face instead of dancing. Harl arrived from town in a hired cart and announced that the village smelled excessively of health.

She had brought the pie pan.

A dent beside the handle caught the lamplight.

Mara looked away from it.

“Sit down,” Harl said. “You make people nervous lurking there.”

Some people were already nervous. They knew Nessa was sheltering somebody from the harbour. A few knew more. Mara had begun to recognise careful silences as readily as the frightened faces from Yseld's errands.

She sat beside Tessa.

Harl served her a sliver of pear.

“For the taste,” she said before Mara could object.

The fruit was soft and faintly smoky. Mara held it in her mouth.

For a moment she was fourteen, her father still alive, stealing the pieces Harl cut away because they looked too bruised to serve.

The stag entered the common while somebody was telling a joke.

At first nobody understood what they were seeing.

Its antlers were hung with thorns, black against the lanterns. One eye had swollen shut. Branches moved against its shoulders, rooted into places where the hide had broken. It stood with its head lowered, drawing air through an open mouth.

The little reed instrument stopped.

Nessa caught Tessa's arm.

“Away from the tables.”

A child ran.

The stag turned.

Mara rose so quickly her chair struck the ground.

The animal hit the end of a table. Bowls flew. A lantern broke in the grass. People were shouting now, stumbling over benches and one another.

Mara reached the child as the stag's antlers swept through the place he had been.

She shoved him beneath a cart.

A thorn tore her cheek.

She heard Tessa shouting her name.

There was a tether rope looped around the cart's front board. Mara pulled it free with her good hand. The stag shook its head, caught on the fallen table, and she saw the opening.

She cast the loop over one antler.

It took the animal one violent movement to pull her off her feet.

Mara hit the ground and slid. The rope burned through her palm. She let it run until the tail reached her, then rolled behind the old pear tree at the edge of the common. While the stag shook its head against the fallen table, she took a round turn about the trunk and secured the tail with two half-hitches.

The stag charged.

The tree took it.

Bark cracked. The rope went hard enough to sing. Mara's shoulder flared with pain, and she let go before the pull tore something inside her.

Two foresters were running towards them with poles.

“Get back!” one shouted.

Mara crawled away.

The animal fought the rope. Its antlers rang in broken notes beneath the thorns.

She did not watch the killing.

Tessa found her beside the cart. The child was crying underneath it, wonderfully alive.

Blood ran down Mara's cheek.

Tessa touched it with the edge of her sleeve.

Across the common, a woman had cut her forearm on a broken bowl. Mara turned towards the smell before she could stop herself.

The woman saw her face.

Saw her mouth.

Someone said the word.

After that, the gathering became a collection of small separate places.

Nessa kneeling beside the injured woman. Harl holding the child's hands and asking him what he had been about to say before all the fuss. Men dragging the dead stag away from the tables. Tessa standing in front of Mara, furious at every pair of eyes that lingered.

“Don't,” Mara whispered.

“Don't what?”

“Stand in front of me.”

Tessa looked at her.

Mara got up. Her knees shook. She crossed the grass to Nessa's house alone.

No one followed until Tessa came with clean water.

For two days people knocked at the door to ask Nessa questions they did not ask Mara. On the third, the child's mother arrived with a repaired bowl and stayed.

She did not offer her arm.

She wanted to know whether Mara had children.

“No.”

“Do you like them?”

Mara thought of the small body beneath the cart.

“Some.”

The woman laughed, startled.

“Sensible answer.”

On the anniversary, rain kept everyone indoors.

Tessa counted the scars on Mara's hand as though she could read the year in them.

“You were meant to be home before supper,” she said.

Mara knew which supper.

“I know.”

Outside, pears fell into the wet grass.

They sat together until morning, and when Tessa finally slept with her head against Mara's good shoulder, Mara stayed where she was.

6. The Door Left Open

Spring 252 IS - eighteen months after turning

Bren arrived at Nessa's door carrying a broken basket.

He held it in front of him while he waited, though nobody could have mistaken it for a reason to come twenty-two kilometres inland.

Mara opened the door.

For a moment neither spoke.

“She's out,” Mara said.

“I came for you.”

His eyes went to the scar on her cheek. It had healed thin and white.

He lifted the basket a little.

“I thought you might -- ”

“I mend sails.”

“I know.”

The absurd basket remained between them.

Mara stepped aside.

The house had grown used to her. That still surprised her sometimes. Nessa shouted for help from the garden without thinking about what she was asking. Tessa left half-finished work on Mara's chair. A neighbour had cut a small extra notch in his doorframe so her measuring cord would fit when she repaired his shutters after dark.

People came for different reasons.

Some of them came to feed her.

Cael had spoken first to adults he knew well. They spoke to others. A few offered once and could not bear to repeat it. Others discovered that what frightened them most was the waiting beforehand. Nessa made people eat in her kitchen afterwards and sent away anyone she thought too tired or unwell.

Mara hated being discussed across a table she was sitting at.

She hated more fiercely the knowledge that she could not live on the kindness of the four people she loved best.

Gradually, the faces multiplied. A fish seller from town. Two orchard households. The potter who played so badly. People whose reasons did not always include affection.

One man said he was helping because his own daughter had run away and he hoped somebody would be decent to her.

Mara had no answer ready for that.

She earned money mending nets and heavy cloth, work brought up by carts and taken away again. She bought her share of oil. The first time Nessa complained that she had chosen an expensive sort, Mara was so pleased that she nearly bought the same kind again.

Now Bren stood in the kitchen looking at the open back door.

“She knows I'm here.”

Mara felt the room change.

“Did she send you?”

He shook his head.

“Bren.”

“No.”

He set the basket down.

His wrist was swollen.

“What happened?”

“She caught me by the arm.”

“When?”

“Three nights ago.”

Mara took a clean cloth from the shelf.

“Sit.”

He obeyed too quickly.

She nearly told him to get up again.

The swelling ran into his hand. He had wrapped it badly, making the pressure worse. As Mara loosened the cloth, he stared at the table.

“I went to your sister.”

“I know.”

“That first morning. I said you were on a boat.”

Mara kept working.

“She asked if you had your coat. I told her there would be one aboard.”

Her hands stopped.

“Why are you telling me?”

“Because I can still hear her asking.”

Outside, Tessa laughed at something Nessa had said. Bren looked towards the sound and then away.

He had helped Yseld before Mara came. At first he repaired things, took money, kept quiet about the shuttered rooms. Later he brought people. One had been a cousin between jobs. Another had needed somewhere to sleep.

“I didn't know how she'd keep them coming back.”

Mara looked up.

He did not finish defending himself.

“Afterwards I knew.”

Tessa came into the kitchen with a bunch of damp roots. When she saw him, her face closed.

“You.”

Bren stood.

“Sit down,” Mara said.

Tessa put the roots on the table with care.

“What does he want?”

“To leave her.”

“Then he can leave.”

Bren looked at the basket.

His wife and children had gone to her sister's household farther inland. He had told Yseld they were visiting. She had put her fingers around his wrist and asked when they would come back.

“I don't think she'll let it end at me,” he said.

Tessa's face changed.

She pulled out a chair and sat.

When Cael arrived that evening, he wanted Bren somewhere guarded. He wanted Mara to stay inside for several nights. He wanted names.

The wants came quickly.

Mara stood from the table.

“I'm going to the garden.”

“We haven't finished.”

“I have.”

He followed her as far as the door.

She turned.

“Leave it open.”

Cael looked at her hand on the latch.

Then he stepped back.

Outside, the new leaves smelled sharp after rain. Mara stood beneath the pear tree until she stopped expecting somebody to call her inside.

Cael came out without his coat.

“I am frightened,” he said.

“I noticed.”

He sat on the low wall. For a while they listened to the brook.

“If she comes here -- ”

“You can tell me what you think she'll do. You can ask me to be careful.”

“And if you aren't?”

Mara looked at him.

He rubbed his face.

“Yes,” he said. “I heard it.”

They made a plan after he went back inside. It was imperfect, involved people Mara did not like needing and sent Bren away by daylight with two cart drivers who knew the roads his family had taken.

Before leaving, he brought the basket to her.

“Keep it.”

“It's broken.”

“Yes.”

Yseld appeared on the forest bank three nights later.

Mara saw her from the upper window.

The brook ran between them, bright under the moon. Crossing it would not hurt Yseld. There was a bridge a little way downstream, and both of them knew it.

What stopped her was the light in Nessa's kitchen, the late visitor stepping out to wash a cup, the two neighbouring doors still open to the mild evening.

Yseld stood beneath the trees until Mara lifted her hand.

Not a greeting.

Enough to show that she had been seen.
Yseld went away.
Mara stayed at the window after she could no longer make out the path.
Below, Tessa began complaining about the expensive lamp oil.
Nessa said she had already dealt with that.
Mara went downstairs to defend herself.

7. A Bowl of Cold Water

Autumn 253 IS - three years after turning

There were eighteen months in which Mara learned how a life could be made without anyone announcing that it was happening.

She acquired a second coat. She stopped waking whenever Nessa shut a door. She found that the boy from the harvest gathering had become unbearable with the confidence of somebody who considered her his particular friend. He brought her damaged things to mend and grew offended when she said some of them had been damaged deliberately.

In winter she worked at a long table in the infirmary, where Cael kept a screened room for her on nights when weather made the road unsafe. Sometimes he fell asleep in the chair opposite, and she listened to his snoring while she sewed.

At Briarbridge, spring meant Tessa's muddy boots appearing in every inconvenient place. Summer meant damp cloths over the shutters and hours lying awake while children shouted in the garden. Mara learned to love the sound without always being grateful for it.

Aelri customers brought old sails to repair. One woman stood beside Mara's table turning the fabric between her hands.

“My mother stitched that seam.”

“It's a good seam.”

“She was insufferable about her work.”

The woman's hair was silver. Mara asked how long the sail had been in use.

“Long enough that I ought to let it go.”

She took it away repaired.

Mara thought about her for several nights afterwards.

Yseld remained part of the weather of their lives.

Cael and the wall captain searched Saint Orra's by daylight after the fire. They found abandoned bedding, old cups and several doors braced from the other side. A worker who sometimes carried supplies to the headland had warned Yseld. The searchers opened the upper rooms and came away without her.

When they returned with masons for the lower chambers, water had risen through one passage. A fisherman admitted seeing an enclosed cart leave by the forest track two mornings earlier.

There were other searches. An empty lime kiln. A loft above a deserted net shed. Each cost people time, wages and courage. Each left somebody saying they should have been quicker.

For months Yseld slept farther down the coast, moving between places whose owners had reason to fear her. She came back when the looking quieted. Mara heard of a man refusing a night errand, of a family leaving suddenly, of blood on an abandoned stair.

Once a stranger knocked at Nessa's and asked whether Mara would come to mend a curtain at a private house.

Nessa shut the door in his face.

“It might have been work,” Mara said.

“It might have been a queen looking for a gardener. I'll survive not finding out.”

That evening they laughed about it.

The next evening Mara checked every shutter twice.

She had begun saving money for a room of her own when Tessa told her about Velisara.

They were washing jars in the garden. Tessa had warmed the water, and little threads of steam rose in the cold air.

“Nessa has a friend there who takes people for a season,” she said. “At a shelter near the wet quays. They see injuries she doesn't often get here.”

Mara turned the jar in her hands.

“What sort of injuries?”

“Burns. Crushed hands. Fevers from the ships. People with bodies I've hardly treated.”

“You aren't finished learning here.”

Tessa looked at her.

“That's the point.”

Beyond the fence, someone was calling a goat by a series of increasingly insulting names.

Mara rinsed the jar.

“It's a long way.”

“Several weeks on the coastal boats, with stops.”

“In autumn.”

“Before the worst weather.”

“They always say that.”

Tessa set down the cloth.

“Who?”

Mara did not answer.

Their father had left before the worst weather too.

Tessa turned back to the water.

“I won't be gone for years.”

Mara heard only the part about being gone.

They managed several days by discussing other things.

Mara made shelves for the room she hoped to rent. One was wider than the others, for Tessa's pots. She measured it twice, cut it badly because her shoulder still stiffened in cold weather, and sanded the crooked edge until it was smooth.

When Tessa saw it, she put a hand on the wood.

“It's beautiful.”

“It will fit under the window.”

“Mara.”

“You can grow things there.”

Tessa took her hand away.

The quarrel came that evening.

It began over a bag.

Tessa had laid out two changes of clothes and the small case of instruments Nessa was lending her. Mara put the clothes back in the chest while Tessa was outside, telling herself she was only making room on the bed.

Tessa came in and looked at the empty bag.

“Put them back.”

“I didn't know you were packing now.”

“Put them back.”

Mara stood beside the chest.

“What if something happens?”

“Something already happened.”

The words struck hard enough that neither spoke for a moment.

Tessa drew a breath.

“I didn't mean -- ”

“You did.”

“I mean I cannot spend every year making sure it doesn't happen again.”

“I never asked that.”

Tessa looked at the clothes in the chest.

Mara wished she had broken something. Broken things could be repaired in ways people recognised.

“If you need me, I can't come,” she said.

It was the truth beneath all the other arguments.

Tessa sat on the bed.

“I know.”

“You don't. There will be days. Whole days when I can't get out of a room. You could be hurt, and I would have to wait.”

Tessa covered her face with both hands.

When she lowered them, her eyes were wet.

“I have been waiting too.”

Mara sat on the floor. It was where her body went when the room had become too difficult.

The little case lay open beside the bag. Inside were forceps, a roll of clean linen and a carved handle fitted to a fine blade. Tessa had polished the metal until it reflected the lamp.

Mara could see part of her own face in it.

After a while she got up and folded the clothes.

She put them in the bag.

Tessa left from Rookharbour on a grey morning two weeks later.

Mara went down the previous night and stayed in Harl's rebuilt storeroom. She walked with Tessa to the quay while there were still stars above the roofs.

The boat smelled of fresh pitch. Its captain was an Urven woman with two small gold rings fitted through one tusk. She inspected Tessa's baggage, asked whether she was likely to be sick, and looked pleased when Tessa said probably.

“Better than finding out you're brave about everything.”

Mara stayed beside a mooring post while the sky paled.

Tessa came back down the gangplank.

For a moment they stood as awkwardly as strangers.

Then Tessa seized her.

“You must go in soon.”

“I know.”

“Promise me.”

Mara nodded against her shoulder.

She left before the boat did.

From behind Harl's opaque shutters she could hear the quay waking, but not which footsteps belonged to Tessa. She sat with a bowl of cold water on her knees because Harl had given it to her to wash her face.

The boat might have departed. It might still be waiting on the tide.

She would not know until somebody came to tell her.

In the afternoon Harl found her asleep in the chair and took away the bowl.

“Foolish girls,” she said quietly.

When Mara woke, the room was dark.

She waited for grief to fill it.

After a while she lit the lamp instead.

8. The House under the Hill

Winter 253-254 IS - thirty-nine months after turning

Harl died because her lungs would not clear.

There was no villain in it. Mara spent days trying to find one.

She blamed the damp wall behind Harl's bed, the winter smoke, the rebuilt kitchen's badly fitted flue. She blamed herself for the fire that had made rebuilding necessary. Nessa listened until Mara began blaming the soup Harl had eaten the previous week, then told her to come and hold a basin.

Tessa was still in Velisara. The first letter had arrived smelling faintly of citrus peel. She wrote about treating a Serev sailor's crushed fingers while somebody explained how his bones differed from hers. She wrote that she had been sick on every boat.

Mara read the letter to Harl twice.

“Serves her right,” Harl said.

She smiled when she said it.

On the last evening they moved her chair to the covered doorway. Mara tucked a blanket around her feet. The harbour lay below them in strips of silver between the houses.

Harl watched a man carrying a sack uphill.

“He'll drop that.”

“He seems to be managing.”

“He's showing off.”

The man dropped it.

Harl made a small satisfied sound.

Mara laughed, and for an instant the room was ordinary.

Later Harl asked for the shutters to be left open.

“You'll be cold.”

“Then bring another blanket.”

Mara stood beside the latch.

Harl looked at her.

“I want the morning.”

There was nothing cruel in her voice.

Mara brought another blanket.

She sat with Harl until light began to gather along the opposite wall. Then she kissed the dry cheek and went into the storeroom.

Nessa came for her after dusk.

They buried Harl in the afternoon the following day. Mara had thought she would resent the hour, but by then resentment required more strength than she could find. She waited in a closed cart beneath a black cover while the others went up the hill. Nobody pretended that she could hear words spoken through earth, wood and distance.

At dusk Cael walked her to the grave.

The soil looked recently wounded.

Mara put Harl's old wooden spoon beside the little clay lamp. Tessa would have chosen something funnier. The thought broke her at last.

Cael stayed until she could stand.

Yseld waited at the bottom of the hill.

Mara saw her before Cael did.

She wore a plain dark coat. The hair above one ear had grown back unevenly. There was a pale ridge where Harl's pan had struck her.

“Go away,” Cael said.

Yseld looked at Mara.

“I'm sorry.”

Mara almost walked towards her.

The shame of that movement kept her still.

“You don't get to come here.”

Yseld lowered her eyes.

“I know what it is to keep living.”

Cael moved between them. When he drew his knife, she retreated into the lane.

Mara watched until she could no longer see her.

Three nights later, she went to Saint Orra's.

She left Nessa a note saying where she was going. It felt cowardly to write what she could not bring herself to say aloud. It felt worse to imagine Cael persuading her to stay.

The road was wet and empty. She passed the lime shed, checked its door, and carried on beneath trees whose bare branches scraped together overhead.

There were new shutters in the monastery kitchen.

Yseld opened the door.

She looked genuinely astonished.

Mara was glad of that, and hated being glad.

“Come in.”

The table had been repaired. A woven rug covered the place where Mara's blood had once dried. There were three chairs now, all sound.

In the corner stood a pile of copper strips wrapped in canvas.

“You've been busy,” Mara said.

“I had to move back before winter. The other places were -- ”

Yseld stopped.

For a moment Mara could see the room behind the sentence: a stranger's loft, a door opening at the wrong hour, the knowledge that a bed existed only while somebody stayed frightened enough to provide it.

Yseld put water on the fire.

“You can still have tea.”

“I know.”

They sat together while it warmed.

Beyond the door, an old bell sounded once.

Mara had forgotten how familiar it was.

“Sometimes I miss this room,” she said.

Yseld's face softened.

“Of course you do.”

“That doesn't mean I should be in it.”

The softness stayed, but something beneath it withdrew.

Yseld poured the tea.

“You think they will keep making room for you.”

“They have.”

“Your sister went away.”

“She is learning.”

“She can learn there. She can fall in love there. Have children. Grow old.”

Mara looked at the steam rising between them.

“I know.”

“Do you?”

She heard a noise beyond the pantry door.

Not an echo. It changed when she turned towards it.

Yseld set down her cup.

“One of the people staying.”

“May I see?”

“She's ill.”

Mara stood.

Yseld caught her sleeve.

Mara looked down at the hand.

After a moment it let go.

The woman in the pantry sat on a pallet beneath a blanket. She was perhaps thirty. A bowl of food lay untouched beside her, and there was a rope around one ankle.

Mara stood in the doorway.

The woman looked at Yseld and began apologising.

“She tried to leave in bad weather,” Yseld said. “She was confused.”

Mara went down on one knee.

“What is your name?”

The woman whispered it. Mara repeated it softly, so she would know it had been heard.

Then she took her knife from her belt.

Yseld seized the back of her coat.

Mara drove an elbow backwards and cut the rope.

The woman crawled away from them.

Yseld struck Mara against the shelves. Pottery broke. Mara felt something sharp enter her side, low beneath the ribs.

For a moment she could not get air.

Yseld had a knife in her hand.

They looked at it together.

“I didn't mean -- ”

Mara kicked her knee.

Yseld fell against the table.

The woman was already at the outer door. Mara followed, holding the wound closed with one hand.

They did not run far.

At the garden gate Mara turned and braced herself against the post. Yseld stood in the kitchen with blood on the knife.

“Come back,” she said.

Mara waited.

Yseld did not come out.

Mara would never know whether grief, pain or the sight of what she had done held her there. She refused to give the uncertainty a kinder name.

The woman helped her along the road.

They reached the lime shed slowly, stopping whenever Mara could not keep walking. The last hour was a series of trees, each one a place to rest before trying for the next.

They shut the door before dawn.

Mara lay on the old straw while the woman packed clean cloth against her side.

“I don't know how to do this.”

“Press.”

“I'm hurting you.”

“I know.”

Outside, wheels sounded on the road.

The woman went to call for help. Mara caught her hand before she opened the door.

She made herself let go.

Cael came that afternoon after the cart driver took word to town. He found Mara feverish, furious and alive.

For several days she could not bear to look at him.

On the fifth, he sat beside the bed and read Tessa's letter aloud.

He did all the voices badly.

Mara told him so.

He started again, worse.

9. What the Day Returned

Spring to summer 254 IS - forty-two to forty-five months after turning

Tessa came home with a sunburned nose, a sea-green cup and a habit of saying “let me see” before touching an injury.

Mara met her at the infirmary after sunset.

For a moment Tessa stood just inside the door, looking at the room.

Mara knew whom she was looking for.

“I kept the spoon,” she said.

Tessa put down her bag.

They held each other for a long time.

The cup had come from a potter in Velisara who fired clay dark on one side and pale on the other. Tessa had wanted two. One broke during the journey home.

“I wrapped yours in my stockings.”

“That was generous of you.”

“They were clean when I started.”

Mara laughed. Tessa cried in the middle of laughing, and then they were sitting on the bed among bags and blankets while Cael discreetly failed to find something in another room.

Later Tessa asked about the wound.

“It's closed.”

“That wasn't what I asked.”

She examined the scar with a care Mara recognised from Nessa, sharpened by practices learned elsewhere. When Mara tried to sit up too quickly and caught her breath, Tessa waited instead of reaching to help.

“You still pull it.”

“Sometimes.”

“Then sometimes you should stop.”

She had seen much in her few months away: a sailor die after an apparently small wound, a child recover against everyone's expectations, an Oshari worker whose fever she had been unqualified to judge. She told the stories without trying to make them proofs of her usefulness.

Mara listened.

“Are you going back?”

“Perhaps one day.”

Mara nodded.

It took effort. Tessa saw the effort and did not punish her for it.

“For now I want to work here.”

“With Nessa?”

“And Cael, when he'll have me. The harbour gets sick whether anyone has finished learning or not.”

Cael appeared in the doorway with the object he had finally found.

It was a spoon.

“We have been managing very badly without you,” he said.

Tessa looked at it.

“I can see that.”

They went to Harl's grave the following evening.

Tessa brought a chipped cup and sat beside the mound for a long while. Mara stood back beneath a tree. She did not ask what her sister said.

When Tessa rose, she left the cup upside down.

“She'd only complain about rain getting into it.”

The room above the rope shed had passed to a distant relative who wanted to rent it. Tessa could have moved into it. Instead she found two rooms behind a cooper's old workshop, close to the infirmary and a little farther from the sea.

“There's a garden,” she told Mara.

“How large?”

“If I spread my arms I nearly touch both walls.”

“Luxury.”

There was a window facing east and a smaller room whose solid shutter could be fitted from inside. Tessa showed Mara both.

“I would like you to live here.”

The words were carefully chosen.

Mara looked at the little garden.

“I'd like that.”

They put up the crooked shelf together.

Mara did not ask Tessa to promise how long she would stay.

Bren returned in late spring.

His wife and children remained inland, safe with people who had made their house difficult for strangers to approach. He had come to move his tools and help two other households do the same.

“They think leaving makes it worse,” he told Mara.

“Sometimes it does.”

“Yes.”

He had stopped arriving with unnecessary objects in his hands.

The woman from the pantry was staying with cousins beyond Briarbridge. Cael had helped her leave without telling Mara where the house was.

Mara resented that for an evening.

Then she remembered the hand she had nearly refused to release in the lime shed.

By summer they had helped several people put distance, witnesses or a changed livelihood between themselves and Yseld. It was not heroic work. There were carts that did not arrive, relatives who refused, people who changed their minds at the last moment. Mara heard anger she had not earned and some she had.

One man told her to get out before his children saw her.

She went.

Another asked if she was still hungry.

She said yes.

He shut his eyes and nodded.

What they were doing reached Yseld quickly.

She confronted Bren near the eastern gardens on a night when Mara and Cael were helping load his last tools.

Mara heard the barrel fall before she saw her.

Yseld had Bren against the workshop wall. His face was wet with blood from a cut above his eyebrow.

“Go inside,” Mara told him.

“He owes me an answer,” Yseld said.

Cael came round the cart.

Yseld looked at the crossbow in his hand.

“You have found another keeper.”

Mara was afraid. The fear was old enough now that she could recognise what it wanted her to do: agree, soothe, promise, return.

She stepped between Yseld and Bren.

“He is going.”

Yseld hit her.

Mara caught the second blow, felt the strength of it in her shoulder and knew she could not hold her long. Yseld's nails cut her cheek. She drove forward, forcing Mara against the cart.

Cael shouted.

Mara twisted aside.

The bolt struck Yseld high in the thigh.

Her cry was startlingly human.

She fell to one knee, seized the cart's wheel and hauled herself back up. Cael was reloading. Mara could have reached her then.

For an instant she wanted to.

She saw the ruined kitchen, Bren on the floor, Tessa holding a letter that did not sound like her.

Then Bren tried to stand. Blood from the wound Yseld had given him ran into his eye. He reached for the doorframe, missed it and collapsed beside the steps, his breathing catching in a wet, irregular rattle.

Mara turned towards him.

Yseld went down the lane, dragging one leg.

Cael started after her.

“Leave it,” Mara said.

“She'll get away.”

“He isn't breathing properly.”

Cael knelt.

Between them they kept Bren alive until Tessa came. Mara held the lamp while her sister checked his eyes, bound the wound and made him answer questions he found increasingly irritating.

“That seems encouraging,” Mara said.

Tessa gave her a tired look.

By dawn Yseld was gone.

They searched again during the day. This time they found a bloodstained blanket in an empty boathouse and tracks where a cart had turned on wet ground. The owners of the cart said a woman had paid for transport and asked them not to look beneath the cover.

She had not given a destination beyond the next coastal landing.

Mara stood in the garden that evening with both hands full of washing.

Tessa took half of it.

“You could have killed her,” Mara said.

She was speaking to herself more than to her sister.

Tessa hooked a sheet over the line.

“Perhaps.”

“I thought about it.”

“I should think you did.”

Wind lifted the cloth between them.

Mara could see Tessa's shadow through it, reaching up to fasten a peg.

“I don't want to keep living like this.”

Tessa came around the sheet.

“Then don't make every good evening wait for her to die.”

Mara looked at the little garden, the fresh wood around the shutter, the clothes moving in the wind.

After a while she handed Tessa the last peg.

10. The Last Invitation

Autumn 255 IS - the eleventh day

During the year that followed, Yseld tried three times to reach Mara.

The first attempt came through a woman who said Yseld was dying. Mara went with Cael and found an empty shed, a mattress and a man waiting behind the door with a club. He dropped it when he saw there were two of them.

The second was an offer of work. By then people knew to ask whose curtains needed mending.

The third was a visit to their garden.

Tessa saw Yseld from the kitchen and shouted before she reached the window. Neighbours came out carrying lamps. Yseld vanished between the houses, leaving a broken pot and a scrape of blood on the wall where she climbed badly.

Her leg healed slowly enough to cost her the summer, but by autumn she was walking without help. What kept her away afterwards was less visible: the loss of Bren's errands, people who had stopped opening doors, watchmen willing to search a shuttered building when a neighbour asked them.

She moved along the coast through winter. Twice someone offered her a room and then betrayed its location. Once a man demanded that she turn him as the price of staying. She left him alive and took his covered cart.

Mara learned these things in fragments. Each report made Yseld seem more dangerous and less immense.

By spring she had returned to Saint Orra's.

A pair of itinerant workers carried copper and timber there for a promised payment. They repaired an upper roof, shifted fallen stone and opened a path to the old hand wheels. When one came back with an injured arm, the other refused to explain what had happened.

The wall captain sent men again. They found the kitchen empty, the lower doors braced, and a human voice behind one of them begging them not to break it open.

Cael went back with a mason. By then the voice was gone.

Mara began sleeping with a knife beneath her pillow.

It made the pillow uncomfortable and her sleep no better.

For much of that year, there was also happiness.

Tessa's little garden produced more beans than either sister wanted. Mara learned to make a stew she could barely eat because Tessa came home too tired to cook. They quarrelled over the washing line. They took turns rescuing a neighbour's ambitious hen.

Cael began coming to supper on nights when the infirmary was quiet. He ate with his sleeves rolled up, and sometimes Mara saw the white mark where he had first given her blood.

He had a new apprentice at the shelter. Tessa found the young man's solemnity exhausting.

“You were worse,” Cael told her.

“You were easier to impress then.”

Bren sent a little barrel from inland. This one was wider at the top.

Tessa stood in the garden laughing with both hands over her mouth.

Mara carried those evenings carefully in her mind. She no longer believed that enjoying them would provoke punishment.

When Tessa failed to come home on the eleventh day of autumn, Mara was stirring the stew.

She waited.

Tessa was often late.

The pot began catching at the bottom. Mara moved it from the heat and sat where she could see the door.

Outside, daylight lay bright across the little garden.

Cael arrived an hour before sunset.

He knocked once, then came in.

Mara stood so quickly the chair fell.

“Tell me.”

A woman had come to the infirmary asking for help at the charcoal burners' hut. A child had fallen. Tessa took her bag and went with her.

The burners knew nothing about it.

Farther along the road, a carter had seen a covered wagon and heard somebody striking its side. He thought it was an animal until a woman's voice shouted from inside. By the time he reached the next bend, the wagon had gone.

“Her bag was in the ditch,” Cael said.

Mara looked past him at the light in the garden.

There were still leaves to fall from the bean vines. A beetle was walking along the rim of Tessa's cup.

“How long?”

“Until sunset? Less than an hour.”

“Don't tell me to wait.”

Cael put the bag on the table.

“I came to wait with you.”

Bren arrived before dark. He had been in town collecting tools for a neighbour when Cael found him.

He looked older than the man Mara remembered on the kitchen floor. So did Cael. She could see the changes now without searching for them.

Neither asked whether she was going.

At sunset they left by the headland road.

Cael and Bren took horses, riding ahead to look for the wagon and leaving one at the lime shed for Mara if she needed it. Mara walked because a strange horse was a poor companion for the terror working through her body. She knew the road beneath her feet. She knew how to keep moving.

In the first hour she planned Yseld's death.

In the second she bargained with gods she had never addressed properly.

By the third she was too tired to do either well.

She stopped at the lime shed, drank water and found Cael waiting.

“Bren's gone ahead.”

“Did you find -- ”

“The wagon. Empty, in the old garden.”

Mara closed her eyes.

Cael gave her a cloth-wrapped cup.

“From an adult at the shelter. Less than four hours ago.”

She stared at it.

She had last fed three nights earlier. He had remembered what fear had made her forget.

“I can't do this now.”

“Then sit until you can.”

She wanted to throw it at him. Instead she sat on the stone step and drank, with tears running down her face and no room left to be ashamed of them.

They walked the last seven kilometres together.

At the monastery, Bren stepped out of the trees.

“She's waiting for you.”

“Tessa?”

He nodded.

“I saw her at the kitchen window. Her hands are tied.”

The three of them stood in the dark garden. The hanging gate had been repaired. Mara noticed that with a sharp, useless anger.

“Stay near,” she said.

Cael caught her sleeve.

She looked at his hand.

He let go.

“We will.”

Yseld opened the kitchen door before Mara reached it.

Tessa sat at the table.

Her face was bruised. Her hands were bound in front of her with strips torn from somebody's shirt. She looked at Mara and shook her head once.

Yseld moved aside.

“Come in.”

Mara did.

The room smelled of fresh-cut timber. Someone had put flowers in one of the cups.

“Let her go.”

“Sit down.”

“Let her go.”

Yseld still favoured the leg Cael's bolt had struck. She set a hand on Tessa's shoulder.

Mara sat.

“I thought we should speak without your friends deciding what you were allowed to hear.”

Tessa looked at the hand on her shoulder.

“You tied my hands.”

“They did that,” Yseld said.

“The woman kept telling me her son was ill. I went to help him. There were two men waiting beside the road.”

Mara watched her sister's bound fingers close.

“They put a blanket over my head. I could still hear her apologising.”

Yseld ignored her.

“There are rooms below that I can keep dry. Proper rooms. We could have a household here.”

“You already had one.”

“I had people who left.”

The answer came so quickly that it seemed to surprise her.

For a moment the old bell sounded beneath the floor.

Mara looked at the flowers.

White autumn asters. Yseld had cut their stems to the same length.

“You could leave too,” Mara said.

Yseld laughed.

“Go where?”

“Somewhere you have not done this.”

“And begin asking again? Find a room someone can take away when they discover what sleeps in it?”

Tessa moved her wrists carefully against the edge of the table.

Mara kept looking at Yseld.

“People can make room.”

“Until they don't.”

“Yes.”

Yseld's face twisted.

“You say that as if you can bear it.”

Mara thought of Harl asking for the morning.

“Sometimes I can't.”

For a moment she saw Yseld understand her.

Then the woman looked at Tessa.

“You will.”

Mara stood.

Yseld pulled Tessa against her, one arm tight across her chest.

“Sit down.”

The back door opened.

Bren entered with empty hands held where Yseld could see them.

“The lower passage is taking water,” he said.

Yseld stared.

“You.”

“One of the new braces is slipping. I heard it from the garden stair.”

Mara saw how quickly Yseld listened.

Beneath the old bell, beneath the kitchen's familiar creaks, came a dull, uneven knocking.

The house had joined the conversation.

11. The Rooms Beneath the Water

Autumn 255 IS - before dawn on the twelfth day

Yseld took Tessa downstairs.

She kept one arm around her while they descended, making a show of helping when Tessa stumbled. Mara followed close enough to see the bruises darkening above the ropes.

Bren came behind her.

The ebb had not yet exposed the lowest passage. They waited for hours on the upper stair, Yseld holding Tessa against her while water lapped across the steps below. Mara asked her to let go until the words lost their shape. Sometimes Yseld answered. Sometimes she spoke instead of the rooms she would make ready. Cael's lamp waited beyond the narrowing water, too far away for a clean shot that would not endanger Tessa.

By the time the passage drained, less than an hour remained before dawn.

At the bottom, Cael stood beside the first of the hand wheels with his lamp raised.

For a moment nobody spoke.

Then Yseld said, “All of you.”

“We came for her,” Mara said.

Water knocked against stone somewhere beyond the wall. The air tasted of salt and the green, enclosed smell of places rarely opened.

Three chambers lay along a sloping passage. In the first, fresh timbers supported a cracked ceiling above an old channel. The second held stone beds crossed with copper, some bright where Yseld had cleaned it. Farther down, a black opening led towards the sea intakes.

Mara remembered being carried through these rooms while the bell rang.

Now she could see the grooves that held the sound.

Cael had placed scored clay beside the lamp. He poured salt water into the marks and began a low, repeated phrase.

The bell grew faint.

Other sounds separated from it: a loose chain tapping, water draining, Tessa drawing a careful breath.

Yseld watched his hands.

“You could have helped.”

“I offered to speak to you.”

“With armed men.”

Cael did not answer.

Bren crouched beside the new bracing.

“This isn't holding the way you think.”

“Don't touch it.”

“I'm a cooper. I know what happens when wet wood swells against a bad joint.”

Yseld's grip tightened. Tessa winced.

Mara took a step.

“Look at her,” she said.

“I am.”

“Then look at what your hand is doing.”

For a moment Yseld looked.

That was when Tessa drove her heel down on the weaker leg.

Yseld cried out. Tessa dropped her weight, twisted beneath the arm and fell against Mara.

Mara pushed her towards Bren.

Yseld struck at them. Mara caught the blow on her forearm and felt something break.

The pain was clean and enormous.

She staggered against the wall.

Bren cut Tessa's bonds.

Cael stopped his phrase. The old bell burst back into the room.

Yseld moved past Mara towards the copper beds.

She laid her hands on the wet strips and began to sing.

It was not beautiful.

Mara had heard her hum in the kitchen. This was work: breath forced into a pattern, each note placed against resistance. Water changed its sound beyond the wall.

The loose chain lifted.

“Yseld,” Bren said.

She did not look at him.

A small, balanced stone gate began to move in the side channel. Water supplied its force through the prepared way; Yseld's failing song held the damaged copper pattern steady. The great shutter behind Cael's wheel remained still.

“She is opening the dry chambers,” Mara said.

She knew the intention from the months she had watched Yseld listening, planning, choosing which room would belong to whom.

Water rushed into a side passage.

The brace above it bent.

Yseld's mouth trembled around the next note.

“Come away,” Mara said.

The song broke.

For one breath, the room was full of ordinary water.

“I can hold it,” Yseld said.

Her weaker leg trembled beneath her. Sweat ran down the side of her face.

Bren looked down the passage.

“We shut the intakes.”

Yseld turned on him.

“You'll lose the lower rooms.”

“Yes.”

She moved towards the wheel.

Mara blocked her.

Behind them Tessa ran to the second wheel, Bren to the third. Cael set down the lamp and took the first with both hands. The main shutter resisted, but the water was near its nightly low. Bren counted aloud, and the three wheels began moving together.

Mara had forgotten how strong Yseld was.

An elbow struck her ribs. Her injured forearm went useless against her chest. She caught the woman's coat with her other hand and held on, letting the stone wall take their weight.

“They will leave you,” Yseld gasped.

Mara pressed her forehead against Yseld's cheek to keep the teeth away from her throat.

“I know they can.”

Yseld bit at her.

Mara drove her knee between them and shoved.

The woman fell against the copper bed.

Behind Mara, the shutter struck home with a sound deep enough to travel through her feet.

Bren ran down the passage to the smaller sea intake. Tessa followed, carrying a wooden wedge. Mara could hear them forcing its lever, then the hammering as Tessa drove the wedge home.

Water kept running, but less fiercely.

Yseld looked towards the sound.

Mara saw calculation give way to something like astonishment.

The dry rooms were going.

They had existed for years in Yseld's mind: a table, familiar steps overhead, somebody sleeping in the next room without planning a departure. Now water moved into the lower chambers through the channels she herself had opened.

“There is still a way up,” Mara said.

Yseld's face was wet. Mara could not tell whether it was sweat or tears.

“You helped them.”

“Yes.”

“I kept you alive.”

“Yes.”

Mara was crying now too. She had not wanted to agree with her at the end.

Cael approached slowly, knife lowered.

“Come up the stairs.”

Yseld looked at him, then at the braced channel.

Mara knew what she was going to do a moment before she moved.

“No.”

“No one is leaving me here.”

Yseld looked towards the stair beneath the edge of the fractured ceiling. She meant to bring the way out down around them. Her eyes never rose to the heavier stone above her own head.

Yseld seized the diagonal timber.

She pulled with the sudden, terrible strength Mara had once mistaken for something inexhaustible.

The joint broke.

For an instant the cracked ceiling remained where it was.

Then stone fell.

Mara caught Yseld by the back of her coat and pulled.

The seam held.

Her broken arm struck the wall. Pain took her breath. Cael grabbed her belt and hauled her backwards as the next slab came down.

Yseld disappeared beneath it.

The sound stopped everything.

Dust filled the lamplight. Water struck the fallen stones and found a different course around them.

Mara tried to go forward.

Cael held her.

“Wait.”

She struck at his hand.

“Wait.”

The last pieces settled.

They reached her together.

The lower half of Yseld's face remained visible, turned towards the passage. Her chest was crushed beneath a slab that had broken through the stone bed. There was no body left beneath it that could draw breath or keep a heart whole.

Cael knelt.

He did not pretend there was something to be done.

Mara stood with her broken arm pressed against her stomach.

She had sewn the seam that had held.

The thought arrived without meaning. Later it would have too much.

Tessa came back along the passage.

When she saw Yseld, she stopped.

For a little while the four living people heard only the water.

Then Bren said they had to leave.

They braced the smaller intake with a second wedge before going up. The collapsed stone had blocked part of its channel; the rest would need proper filling when daylight brought workers and clear eyes. Nobody called the place safe.

Cael retrieved his lamp. He left the cracked clay behind.

The bell returned faintly as they climbed.

In the kitchen, the flowers still stood in their cup.

Tessa put on her coat with hands that would not stop shaking.

Mara sat on the good chair.

Outside, the first birds had begun.

They could not make the road before dawn. Cael and Bren checked the upper pantry, took away the rope and covered every crack with the soundest of the old curtains. Tessa stayed beside Mara while Cael set her arm.

It hurt so much she thought she would be sick.

“Tell me something,” she said to Tessa.

“What?”

“Anything.”

Tessa told her about the captain who had taught her how to be seasick without apologising.

She told it badly because she was crying.

Mara listened.

At daylight Bren went down the road to bring help. Cael sat outside the pantry door with his back against the wall.

Tessa lay beside Mara on the cleanest blankets they could find.

The house creaked around them.

Neither slept for a long time.

12. A Light in the Kitchen

Autumn 255 IS - the eighteenth day

The masons filled the damaged channels with broken stone and lime.

Mara heard about it from bed.

They closed both sea intakes, secured the shutters and brought down the parts of the lower passage that could not be braced safely. The eastern gardens would not take another season of water from the old workings. Saint Orra's lower rooms filled and stayed wet. The service crypt could no longer be reached without passing through them.

The chapel remained above it all, open to rain.

People would still go there with flowers.

The workers brought Yseld up before they sealed the passage. They wrapped what remained of her in two lengths of plain cloth and buried her on the headland, away from the paths.

Cael told Mara where.

She did not ask whether anyone had lit a lamp.

He told her that too.

For the first days she woke expecting Yseld.

A footstep outside the door, a hand on the latch, the sound of someone checking a curtain. Her body prepared for the old demands before memory caught up with it.

When Tessa came in, Mara sometimes flinched.

Tessa learned to speak from the doorway.

The broken arm needed weeks in splints. Cael said it would be longer before she could work with it properly. Her side and shoulder ached from the struggle, and there were bruises she had not noticed until nobody was trying to hurt her.

Tessa had bruises too.

She refused to let Mara apologise for each one.

On the sixteenth evening of autumn, Nessa arrived with a covered dish and inspected both sisters.

“You look dreadful,” she told Mara.

“It's good to see you too.”

“You look tired,” she told Tessa.

“I am.”

“Excellent. One sensible answer.”

She stayed while Tessa went out to work at the infirmary. Mara listened to her moving around the kitchen, complaining about the arrangement of the shelves.

After a while Nessa came to the doorway.

“The crooked one's hers, I take it.”

“Mine.”

“I thought you were meant to be the useful one.”

Mara laughed. It hurt, but not badly.

Nessa sat beside the bed.

She smelled of damp wool and crushed leaves. The cuffs of her coat were shiny from years of use. Mara looked at the lines around her eyes and did not look away.

“You tried to pull her out,” Nessa said.

Mara closed her eyes.

“I don't know why.”

“You might never settle on one reason.”

The answer was unexpectedly restful.

Mara had been trying to choose the correct feeling since the ceiling fell. Relief came with shame behind it. Grief arrived carrying memories she did not want to honour. Anger made her feel disloyal to herself for ever having wanted the kitchen back.

Nessa took up a loose button from the bedside table.

“Who does this belong to?”

“My coat.”

“Where's your sewing box?”

Mara told her.

They left the other things unfinished.

On the seventeenth night, Bren came to supper.

He brought apples and a little wooden frame that would hold heavy cloth steady while Mara worked with one hand. He had made the grips too tight, and the first attempt split a scrap of sail.

He stared at it, horrified.

Mara began laughing.

“It's a beginning.”

“I'll change the teeth.”

“Tomorrow.”

He looked towards the window.

“Yes,” he said. “Tomorrow.”

His family would remain inland through winter. He was going back after finishing the work he had promised in town. He spoke about them without first checking whether someone was listening outside.

Cael arrived late, carrying bread.

Tessa made him wash his hands before touching anything.

He obeyed with the air of a man suffering a personal injustice.

There were five places at the little table, though Nessa insisted she had only come to collect her dish. Tessa found another chair. Bren moved his knees out of everyone's way and then immediately put them in someone else's.

For a while supper was mostly adjustments.

Mara sat beside the wall, with her splinted arm resting on a cushion and a cup before her.

She had fed earlier that evening. A willing adult from the orchard households had come down with Nessa, stayed to be checked and gone to a cousin's house for the night. Mara still disliked the moment before a meal, the bright hunger that could reduce a room to one person's arm. She had stopped imagining that disliking it would make her safe.

Tonight the hunger was quiet.

She tasted a spoonful of broth and let the warmth stay in her mouth.

Cael was describing a child who had put a bean up his nose to prove it could be done. Tessa maintained that the boy had proved his point. Nessa wanted to know why everyone assumed his next experiment would be more sensible.

Bren laughed with his whole face.

Mara reached for her cup and almost used the wrong hand.

Tessa moved it nearer without stopping her argument.

After supper they spoke of the headland.

Briefly.

Bren wanted to know whether Mara needed anything from the kitchen before the upper rooms were closed against winter.

She thought of the brass hairpin, the cracked tile and the charcoal drawing folded white at its corners.

“There was a blue tile wrapped in cloth,” she said. “If it's still there.”

He nodded.

“I'll look.”

Nobody asked her to explain.

Nessa and Bren left together before midnight. Cael stayed to check Mara's arm, then went back to the infirmary. Tessa washed the dishes while Mara dried the unbreakable things one-handed and was told she was slowing everything down.

They did not hurry.

The eighteenth day of autumn began quietly.

At the corresponding dawn five years earlier, Mara had drawn breath beneath Saint Orra's and reached towards a strip of light.

Now she sat in her own kitchen while Tessa checked the inner shutter.

“I can do that,” Mara said.

“With one hand?”

“Badly.”

“Then you can have it back when you've got two.”

Tessa fastened it and came to stand beside her.

She was twenty-two now. There were new lines at the corners of her mouth when she smiled, very faint, made by sun and weather and the habit of speaking plainly. She had grown older than the face Mara still found in mirrors.

Mara had imagined that moment would feel like theft.

Instead she touched her sister's sleeve.

“I'm glad you went.”

Tessa knew where.

She leaned against Mara's good shoulder.

“So am I.”

Outside, somebody opened a shop shutter. A cart went past with a loose wheel making its familiar knock. The first light reached the garden wall and stayed there, beyond the solid wood.

Mara did not have to move.

Tessa straightened.

“I have to go. Cael will forget to eat if someone doesn't arrive and insult him.”
She put on her coat, tucked her instruments into the bag and paused at the door.
There was nothing left to promise that morning.
“Sleep well,” she said.
Mara listened to her steps cross the little garden.
Then she went into the dark room, lay down carefully around the splints, and slept.